▶ MADHYA PRADESH

MOHAN YADAV'S MERRY-GO-ROUND

The equation is: 19 months, 19 bureaucrats. That's how busy the turnstiles have been at the CMO. But why?

By **Rahul Noronha**

STABILITY FOR THE GOVERNMENT may be a foregone conclusion in Madhya Pradesh, where the ruling BJP holds 164 out of 230 seats in the assembly, but the same cannot be said about stability of bureaucratic tenures. Even in the chief minister's secretariat, where the occupants are usually handpicked by the CM himself.

A total of 19 IAS officers have been shifted in and out of the CM secretariat in as many months of the Mohan Yadav regime, both at the top and middle levels of the organisation. That unprecedented tenurial instability in an all-powerful department prompts the question: is the CM unable to find a team he trusts? Or does he defer to other people's decisions?

It's a fast-paced chronology that may still leave you clueless after a close perusal. Soon after Yadav took over in December 2023, Raghvendra Singh, a 1997 batch IAS officer, was brought in as principal secretary in the CMO; Bharat Yadav, a 2008 batch IAS officer, became secretary. A couple of months later, reports emerged of a lack of coordination between the two. In June 2024, two more loops were added to the knot: Rajesh Rajora and Sanjay Shukla as additional chief secretary and principal secretary, respectively. In October, Anurag Jain, a 1989 batch IAS officer, joined as chief secretary—the buzz at the turnstiles suggested the hand of New Delhi. Soon afterwards, Singh and Shukla were transferred out. In January 2025, secretary Yadav was replaced by batchmate Sibi Chakravarthy. In early July, Neeraj Mandloi, a 1993 batch IAS officer, replaced Rajora. Two weeks later, Chakravarthy also exited; in came Chandramauli Shukla.



Takeaways

- **19 bureaucrats have been shifted in and out of the CM secretariat in 19 months**
- **The instability impacts work beyond CMO; Yadav handles as many as 11 ministries**

A TRADITION OF TRUST

Top sources affirm the CM's concurrence on all these postings. But why is the CMO not a settled affair? Contrast this with the tenurial stability that characterised the reigns of past CMs. In the Shivraj Singh Chouhan years, Iqbal Singh Bains did two stints in his CMO. Digvijaya Singh, on his part, had R.N. Berwa and R. Gopalakrishnan in his CMO for substantial durations.

Some crucial ingredient of durability is clearly missing. "The CM would have to firstly develop trust with his bureaucrats to ensure stable tenures. Most of the officers considered for key assignments had worked with the CM when he was a minister or chairperson of the Tourism Development Corporation or were posted in the CM's hometown Ujjain. It's been one and a half years and he should have had a team of his own by now," says Girija Shankar, veteran political commentator and MP watcher.

The CMO is a critical office in all states but more so in MP right now because CM Yadav holds as many as 11 key portfolios: Home, Forests, Mining, Industries, General Administration, Civil Aviation, Jail, Public Relations, Public Services Management, NRIs and Narmada Valley Development Authority (NVDA). So the CMO has to function as the minister's office for these departments as well. ■

Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**